THE CM'S TEAM

The Cabinet

C. Joseph Vijay
Chief Minister, Tamil Nadu



Bussy N. Anand: *TVK general secretary and a veteran aide to Vijay*



Aadhav Arjuna: *Son-in-law of lottery king Santiago Martin; key negotiator in reeling in rebel AIADMK MLAs*



K.A. Sengottaiyan: *10-time MLA and ex-AIADMK minister, brings huge administrative experience*



Dr K.G. Arunraaj: *Ex-IRS officer and medical doctor leads party's policy and propaganda efforts*



Rajmohan: *Popular digital creator and media personality is party's propaganda secretary*



S. Keerthana: *Sivakasi MLA is the youngest cabinet member at 29. Only woman in cabinet as of now*

tralised but disciplined party machinery capable of surviving electoral cycles and governance pressures. Right now, the TVK is just a party created from his fan base and turncoats from other parties. If the party is to survive future challenges, the current volunteer force will have to transform into a regimented political party structure, especially at the booth level. The TVK's sweeping win in its first ever election— a 'black swan' event, according to the BJP's K. Annamalai at least—may not be so easy next time around. Future elections will not give the TVK the 'unknown outsider' advantage against entrenched parties.

OPENING ROUNDS

Among the most headline-grabbing announcements of the new TVK government has been the closure of around 700 state-owned TASMAC liquor outlets, particularly those located near schools, colleges, places of worship and crowded public spaces. Alongside this, the government has announced special initiatives focused on women's protection and public safety.

Politically, these are highly effective opening moves. Liquor regulation has long been an emotionally resonant issue in Tamil Nadu, especially among women voters. Every major party has, at different moments, promised some form of restriction on alcohol sales while simultaneously relying heavily on TASMAC revenue to fund welfare commitments while in power.

Talking of the latter, Vijay and the TVK could rack up a humongous bill with their pre-poll promises. Analysts say the welfare spend could add up to an outgo of nearly Rs 1 lakh crore every year, accounting for one-third of the state's total revenues. Gold guineas for new brides and rings for newborns, six free gas cylinders for every family, cash doles to mothers, women, jobless graduates, farmers, the list goes on. Balancing the books might be a more onerous task now, and even Stalin couldn't resist taking a backhanded jibe at Vijay, asking, "Didn't you know this before making promises to the people?"

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Meanwhile, another move by the new administration—the appointment of his high-flying astrologer, Radhan Pandit Vetrivel, to the crucial post of CM's officer on special duty (OSD)—was not just controversial but also exposed Vijay's inexperience. TN is still the land of the great rationalist thinker Periyar, who the Dravidian parties—and even Vijay—set much store by, so the appointment got flak from every corner. The new CM had to back down on it within days.

Going forward, the TVK government will have to prioritise its challenges. Chief among them will be the fragile coalition government with the Congress (the others are offering outside support). Managing constructive ties with the BJP-led government at the Centre will also require Vijay's constant ministrations, especially with Congress in the mix—with stakes. Lastly, the TVK cannot even appear to be cowed down on crucial issues such as Hindi, NEET and GST, for the big Dravidian parties will be waiting and watching, ready to pounce.

Tamil Nadu politics has historically rewarded leaders who successfully merge spectacle, welfare and emotional connection. But those comparisons also create enormous expectations. Charisma may win elections, but governance ultimately determines political longevity. The first week of the TVK government has showcased more symbolism than structural policy shifts. Vijay has shown a sharp instinct for public mood, media optics and political messaging. These are valuable tools, but the larger challenge before him is to hone those instincts so as to create a coherent governing philosophy—one capable of sustaining both his popularity and institutional credibility in one of India's most politically complex states. ■